

Coping with Messiness in Ethnography: Authority, Bias and Immersion in ethnographic Fieldwork in the non-Western World

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ABSTRACT

Ethnography has firmly established its position in the Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) community. Many studies have benefited from following ethnographic approaches to arrive at a grounded and comprehensive understanding of the respective research context. Applying that to the non-Western world, however, comes with challenges for researchers. Aside from ethical concerns which have been addressed in the past, we want to use this workshop to foster conversations and discussions on authority, bias and immersion when conducting ethnographic field work in the non-Western world – especially as a Western researcher. The main objective of this workshop is to exchange experiences and to identify common aspects and ways of overcoming, coping with or even embracing the messiness in ethnographic work and derive guidelines based on these discussions.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → Human computer interaction (HCI); HCI design and evaluation methods; Field studies; Human computer interaction (HCI); Empirical studies in HCI; Human computer interaction (HCI); HCI theory, concepts and models.

KEYWORDS

Ethnography, Authority, Bias, Immersion, non-Western World, Global South

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1 BACKGROUND

Ethnography is gradually becoming more common in Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) and in technology design [2, 5, 9], and various studies have benefited from the strength that ethnographic approaches have in obtaining rich and grounded understanding of local contexts [16]. As HCI have recently expanded its interest in investigating more diverse populations and settings [1, 4, 11, 13, 14, 21, 23, 26], this has paved the way to new design opportunities but also different kinds of challenges and complexities [12, 20, 22]. Previous workshop in the CHI sphere have dealt with uncertainty in HCI [22], the necessity of sensitivity in research, practice and design [8], and HCI across borders [15], bringing together global HCI researchers in order to apply the potential benefits of a significant and heterogeneous user base. Further, ethical encounters [24, 25] in ethnographic field work have been addressed. Although all these previous workshops have some minor overlaps with our workshop proposal, they did not tackle the themes of bias, immersion and authority in ethnographic fieldwork, especially in the non-Western world. We therefore aim at making a contribution to this growing field by unravelling further dimensions.

This workshop is dedicated to unpacking these messy challenges and complexities that arise when carrying out ethnographic fieldwork in a non-western setting. Ethnography depends to a large extent on the kinds of interactions and relationships that the researcher establishes in the field site with different participants [6]. Therefore, the ethnographer relies on a certain degree of immersion in the cultural context and practices one is studying [7, 18]. However, deep immersion needs to be carefully balanced, preserving the researcher's critical stance to reflect. Coping with issues of immersion to, and separation from, the field site is not always simple and straightforward. Reflections about this bias, open pathways to reflect immersion in the various fields of researchers as well. Becoming part of a field, organisation or group relates strongly to potential biases [27]. Where are the borders between being an actual part of – and performing to be a part – of a community drawn? Carrying out an ethnographic study implies constant considerations, related to the researcher's position, but also potential bias (e.g., regarding

the role of the researcher and the type of data to be collected) [12]. A few studies have shown how biases become ultimately inscribed in technology design [17]; however, little is known about how to cope with biases from a methodological perspective, but also from a design perspective when translating users' needs and experiences.

Strongly related is the notion of authority manifested not only in researchers and participants, but also in organisations and political systems in which the field site is embedded [3, 5, 10]. While a researcher might invest great efforts in establishing their ethnographic authority, it is not a static property that researchers pose once and for all. There have been reports of consciously influencing the field and its agents due to a self-perceived authority, especially in non-western contexts and politically unstable situations – using one's own identity to reach certain goals – like passing checkpoints or gaining access to stakeholders and organizations. Changes in circumstances and settings, may result in a circumvented, redefined, or even lost authority. Here we wish to welcome experiences of challenges related to the researcher's authority and various informal ways of reclaiming and re-establishing one's authority.

While similar methodological challenges have been discussed in the literature, greater attention needs to be dedicated to these 'messy' aspects that ethnographic fieldwork entails. The translation from what one has seen, experienced and witnessed and how that translates to user needs and ultimately manifests in design has not yet been in the focus of the CHI community. The aim of this workshop is to share experiences and identify common aspects and workarounds of messiness in ethnographic work. Participants are invited to critique and rethink current concepts, methods and frameworks of ethnographic fieldwork that do not serve research in the non-Western world. The key objectives of the workshop are:

- Establishing a community of ethnographic researchers to foster exchange on on-going challenges and barriers;
- Sharing, discussing, criticising and rethinking existing methods, coping mechanisms and strategies;
- Formulating guidelines to address challenges when conducting ethnographic research (work in progress);

All contributions will be published as a paper compendium on the website. These will allow for long term engagement with the content and enhanced collaboration among attendees. Using digital tools, and informed by contributions and discussions during the workshop, we will also put together a compilation of the different resources for a wider audience to engage in the discourse. This collection will be published on the workshop website together with a link to the tool used in the workshop.

This workshop is based on discussions and outcomes from them workshop (*Coping with Messiness in Ethnography: Methods, Ethics and Participation in ethnographic Field Work in the non-Western World* [19], hosted in a virtual format at the ECSCW 2020 conference in Siegen, Germany. With a total of 24 participants, ranging from undergraduates to emeritus professor, from the field of HCI, Informatics, AI, Media, Journalism, Anthropology, we created a network of researchers facing challenges in conducting ethnographic field work. Messy ethnography is a format aiming at growing this network into various research communities and allow for diverse reflections on the broader discourse, focusing on its aspects with

each workshop. Further information of the previous workshop can be found here: <http://messy-ethnography.org/>

2 ORGANIZERS

Each of the organizers has a long history of conducting ethnographic work in a variety of settings, and in particular has experienced challenges and struggles in applying methods to non-Western contexts. Through the exchange of these experiences between the various co-organizers, this workshop was initiated. Every organizer will present their own position about balancing objectivity, bias and immersion during the introduction of the workshop to start the discussion and open the floor for the participants.

Marios Mouratidis (main contact) is a PhD student and a research associate at the chair of Computer-supported Cooperative Work and Social Media, University of Siegen. His research focuses currently on participation, maker methodologies, digital fabrication (makerspaces and fab labs) and (social) innovation in Germany and Palestine. He has conducted fieldwork in Palestine over the past four years investigating volunteerism in come_IN Computer Clubs in Palestinian refugee camps, as well as entrepreneurial, artistic and social innovation communities in the area.

Sarah Rüller is a PhD student and research associate at the Institute for Information Systems and New Media, University of Siegen and the Collaborative Research Centre 1187 "Media of Cooperation". Her current research focuses on technology appropriation in non-urban areas, social innovation and informal and computer-supported project-based learning. Since 2015, she has conducted ethnographic field work in the High Atlas Mountains, Morocco and in the West Bank.

Konstantin Aal is a PhD student and a research associate at the Institute for Information Systems and New Media, University of Siegen. He is part of come_IN, a research project which founded several computer clubs for children and their relatives including refugees. Over the past years, he conducted research in various settings, ranging from refugee camps in the West Bank, over developing a lion alert system in Botswana and establishing a media space in the High Atlas. His current research focuses on technology appropriation by local communities in the Global South and how this kind of technology is and can be used for activism.

Nina Boulus-Rødje is an Associate Professor in the Sustainable Digitalization Research Group at Roskilde University (Denmark). Throughout her career, she has carried out qualitative research, studying digitalization processes across various organizations and sectors. This includes, case handling systems in employment agencies in Denmark, e-voting technologies in Denmark, as well as electronic patient records in Canada and in Norway. She is also interested in the potentials of information technologies in conflict and post-conflict context. In the past seven years, she has carried out research in Palestine, focusing on the tech-entrepreneurial scene. With a strong interest in studying technologies and work practice, she is equally interested in methodologies used for studying these. She has written several articles about various forms of engaged scholarship and interventionist research.

Shaimaa Lazem is an Associate Research Professor at City of Scientific Research and Technological applications, Egypt. Her research interests include participatory design, post-colonial

computing, and decolonizing HCI. Her previous projects included designing heritage documentation applications for rural populations.

Anicia Peters is the Pro-Vice Chancellor for Research, Innovation and Development and Associate Professor at the University of Namibia. She is a native of Namibia and passionate about inclusion research and inclusive tech development. She is the initiator of the Africa HCI Conferences (AfriCHI). She is one of 10 African women in technology rolemodels and recipient of a recent Google Award for Inclusion Research. Her research work spans social media, gender, e-participation such as digital health and digital government.

Simon Holdermann is a research assistant at the CRC 1187 "Media of Cooperation" and doctoral candidate at the Department of Social and Cultural Anthropology as well as a fellow of the a.r.t.e.s. Graduate School for the Humanities at the University of Cologne. For his recently completed doctoral project, which was developed within this interdisciplinary framework, he conducted research in the High Atlas in Morocco. The overarching research question revolved around the role of media technology within the context of profound socio-technical transformations in the mountain region. In particular, the entanglement of development cooperation, tourism and NGO became the focus of ethnographic attention.

Vasilis Vlachokyriakos is an Assistant Professor in Human-Computer Interaction and Digital Civics at the School of Computing at Newcastle University, Open Lab. He is also a co-founder and trustee of Open Lab Athens, a non-for-profit digital civics lab based in Athens. Vasilis' work centres on designing novel digital infrastructures for civic participation through place-based, participatory and action-led research aiming at the development of systems for cooperative work, particularly in-service provision. As part of this research agenda Vasilis is an investigator in the H2020 "Generative European Commons Living Lab" (Ge.CO Living Lab), of the H2020 "Digital Disruptive Technologies to co-create, co-produce and co-manage Open Public Services" (CO3) project, a co-investigator on the EPSRC Digital Economy Research Centre, and a co-investigator of the EPSRC "Centre for Digital Citizens".

Ann Light is Professor of Design and Creative Technology, University of Sussex, UK, and Professor of Interaction Design, Social Change and Sustainability, Malmo University, Sweden. She is a qualitative researcher specializing in design for social wellbeing, the politics of participation and social innovation, with a particular interest in creative practice for transformations to sustainability and the social impact of networking. She also studies how grassroots organizations use design and technology. She has worked with arts and neighbourhood organizations and marginalized groups on five continents, in local, transnational and international development settings and run an international charity devoted to cultural exchange using digital media.

Volker Wulf is a computer scientist with an interest in the area of IT system design in real-world contexts, this includes the development of innovative applications from the areas of cooperation systems, knowledge management and community support. One special focus lies on flexible software architecture which can be adapted by end-users. Further research focuses on methods of user-oriented software development and introduction processes. He is

head of the Institute for Information Systems and New Media at the University of Siegen.

Dave Randall's research interests center on the use of ethnographic methods in technology-related fields, mainly for design and evaluation purposes. He has published extensively in this area. A specific interest lies in understanding the uses of new technology by less-well understood groups and communities and he has supported the work of researchers in areas like Colombia, Brazil, Bosnia-Herzegovina, Palestine and North Africa. He is the author of seven books and over 100 peer reviewed papers.

3 PRE-WORKSHOP PLANS

The proposed workshop will be promoted through the currently existing website and the accompanying mailing list. In addition, a broad variety of mailing lists as well as personal contacts and social media groups (such as ArabHCI, HCIxBorders, Facebook groups, different mailing lists) will be used to spread the workshop and reach researchers, activists and practitioners. Candidates will be required to submit a position paper (2 - 5 pages) discussing their current, previous or planned work. These papers can be in immediate relation to ethnographic work, examples of work which was challenging with regard to the mentioned aspects or raise questions in this discourse which have not yet been addressed. We envisage a maximum of 20 participants (excluding organizers), who will be selected based on the relevance and potential contribution of their position paper to the workshop scope and activities. In addition, a summary of each individual workshop contribution (max. 1 page) should be submitted as well, in order to be shared amongst all participants.

4 WORKSHOP STRUCTURE

Based on previous experiences and the current situation with the pandemic, the entire CHI2021 as well as this workshop will be fully digital. We intend to structure the workshop into several phases: pre-activities, a two-day workshop in the timeframe of CHI2021 and follow-up activities. In order to prevent screen-fatigue, the main workshop will be divided into three-hour events over two days (Japan Standard Time), with a number of activity-breaks in-between. The final timeframe will be set after position papers are accepted, in order to allow to find a suitable and fair timeframe depending on the time zones of the participants.

By having pre- and follow-up activities, participants will be working in pre-assigned groups prior to the actual conference event will enable a deeper and richer exchange, discussion and results are to be expected. After the conference, follow-up sessions are planned either with the whole group of participants or in the smaller groups. By organising the whole workshop in this structure, we will enable for a richer experience and participation, but also strengthen our community, as opposed to having one single touch point of engagement during the conference.

4.1 Pre-Activities

The first virtual meeting will be held with all accepted participants to get to know each other and exchange work experiences from the field. Everyone will have to read only a short summary of the submissions to get a brief idea of each attendee's experience and take

on the workshop's scope. Following those brief introductions, the organizers will engage with the participants in sub-groups based on the submitted position papers and research interests. Each sub-group will address a different theme of the workshop, which will be presented during the two-day event at the conference. In addition, digital tools for asynchronous work (e.g. Miro, Mural) will be set up to support the different sub-groups. Here, other participants from the workshop can also take part in the on-going discussions and work of the other sub-groups. The advantage of the asynchronous communication and collaboration allows all participants to participate regardless of their time zones.

4.2 Two-Day CHI Workshop

The two-day event is planned to be an interactive workshop, during which the participants will continue working on different tasks and questions raised in the pre-activities, instead of presenting their previous and current work. The workshop will begin with an icebreaker and catching up on prior work before the morning coffee break. Following the morning coffee and lunch breaks, participants will continue to work in their small groups. The aim is to conclude the discussions and results of their pre-workshop activities in order to share the results within the group and carry on the discussion with new contributions from the other groups. The workshop will conclude with a plenary discussion of the results with an outlook to future plans for a collaboration and the after-activities.

By setting up the sub-groups in the pre-workshop activities as well as the digital tools, the participants will be more familiar with those tools and will also know each other in advance. Therefore, the barriers and challenges to participate in the various workshop activities via a video communication system (e.g. Airmet, Shindig, Zoom, Wonder) is lower.

Timetable CHI Workshop First Day

19:00 - 19:15	Welcome
19:15 - 19:45	Icebreaker and recap by the Organizers
19:45 - 20:00	Coffee break
20:00 - 21:00	Continuation of work in the existing groups
21:00 - 21:15	Coffee break
21:15 - 22:15	Continuation of work in the existing groups
22:15 - 22:30	Closing First Day

Timetable CHI Workshop Second Day

19:00 - 19:15	Welcome and recap by the Organizers
19:15 - 20:00	Continuation of work in the existing groups
20:00 - 20:15	Coffee break
20:15 - 21:15	Finalising work in the existing groups
21:15 - 21:30	Coffee break
21:30 - 22:30	Discussion in the whole group
22:30 - 23:00	Closing remarks and next steps

4.3 Follow-Up Activities

The workshop community will continue to work on the overall topics or the different themes of the workshop. The groups as a whole will decide together what the next steps are: mutual plans for upcoming events for this format, mutual publications based on the results, further development of the network and potentially drafting of guidelines for ethnographic fieldwork.

5 POST-WORKSHOP PLAN

All results (i.e. notes, documentation and other materials) that are created during the discussions will be shared amongst the workshop participants and revised, prior to being uploaded to the selected digital tools and being made available for the network and everyone else interested in the discourse. For further discussions on the topic, a journal special issue will be prepared, which will present the outcomes of the workshop and provide the opportunity for others to join the discussion (the venue is not yet specified and will be discussed with the involved participants). Follow-up workshops on other conferences (see next paragraph) will help this newly formed network to grow and allow for collaboration on the important topics at hand. Through discussions and new initiatives, more researchers will be on-boarded to reflect upon their own challenges with ethnographic field work. In addition, the workshop participants will become part of a network which serves as a support line when help is needed in dealing with an uncommon situation.

Currently, we are planning a workshop titled "*Disrupted Ethnography: Practical Perspectives and Access to the Field*", aiming at bringing together journalists, activists, practitioners and researchers to discuss common obstacles and approaches. The workshop is planned to take place in July 2021. We are planning to combine the networks from the ECSCW 2020 workshop, CHI 2021 and the one in July 2021 to create a bigger community around issues in ethnographic fieldwork in Human Computer Interaction and Computer-supported Cooperative Work.

6 CALL FOR PARTICIPATION

This CHI workshop aims to provide a forum for researchers as well as practitioners and activists to discuss challenges in conducting ethnographic fieldwork that goes beyond the book(s) and to start working on guidelines that are more practical and viable to adapt in non-Western contexts. The topics include but are not limited to coping with bias, immersion and authority in field research, the relations between and the fine granular aspects related to those discourses. This intends to begin a dialogue in order to mutually reflect on and inform new guidelines for our work methodologies and approaches.

We invite anyone interested in participating to submit a two to five-page position paper, as well as a one-page summary. Papers should critically reflect upon the authors' experiences from the field or research area related to challenges they face when conducting ethnographic fieldwork. Authors' prior experience does not have to be specifically concerned with these challenges, but the position papers will be expected to demonstrate how their experience is relevant to the workshop's topic and can be applied within the workshops' context.

Submissions should be sent to info@messy-ethnography.org in .pdf format. Position papers will be reviewed based on relevance and potential for contribution to the workshop. At least one co-author of each accepted paper must register to CHI 2021 to attend the workshop.

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